BUSINESS PROCESS INNOVATION

Industry Visit — Investigation Checklist & Question Log

Complete this checklist after your visit. Each □ confirms a question was asked and answered in your separate Answer Report.

Student Name	Organization	Industry Vertical	Visit Date(s)
Hari Haran K	Arumbu foods	Manufacturing	2/4/2026

⚠ *This document contains ONLY questions. Write all answers in your separate Answer Report. Refer to the page numbers shown in each section header of your Field Manual.*

DAY 1 Orientation, Overview & The Big Picture

1 BUSINESS OVERVIEW & END-TO-END FLOW

Refer: Field Manual pp. 6–7

☑ **Core Purpose**	What exact product or service does this business provide? What specific problem does it solve for its customers?
☑ **Revenue Model**	How does this business make money? What is the single transaction that drives its revenue?
☑ **Customer**	Who are the primary customers? Are there different types with different needs? How do they typically find this business?
☑ **Department Map**	List every department or function in this organization. How do they relate to and depend on each other?
☑ **Single Unit**	Choose one real order, patient, or service request. Trace it step by step from the moment the business first received it to the moment it was fully completed. Name every department it passed through.
☑ **Time at Each Step**	For the single unit you traced – how long did each step actually take, and how long did the unit wait between steps?
☑ **Biggest Risk**	At which stage of the end-to-end journey did stakeholders say they feel the most uncertainty or the highest risk of failure?
☑ **Most Critical Task**	What is the single activity that, if it stopped, would immediately affect everything else in the business?

2 ROUTINE TASKS & DEPENDENCY VULNERABILITIES

Refer: Field Manual pp. 7–8

☑ **Daily**	What tasks must happen every single day regardless of customer orders? List them all.
☑ **Weekly / Monthly**	What tasks happen every week, every month, or on a periodic schedule (compliance, audits, payments)? Are they formally scheduled?
☑ **System vs.**	For each routine task: is it tracked by a formal system, written checklist, or software reminder — or does it happen only because someone remembers to do it?
☑ **Task Ownership**	Is there a clearly assigned person responsible for each routine task, or is responsibility assumed or shared informally?
☑ **Impact of**	Has any routine task ever been missed? What happened? Was the impact understood beforehand?
☑ **Dependency Test**	If the most experienced person handling these tasks was unavailable for 30 days, which specific tasks would collapse? Why exactly would they

	collapse?
☑ **Handover Readiness**	If that person had to hand over tomorrow, how long would training take? What would a new person most likely get wrong?

3 LEAD & ORDER CAPTURE SYSTEMS

Refer: Field Manual pp. 8–9

☑ **Inquiry**	How do new customers first contact this business? List every channel: phone, walk-in, WhatsApp, website, exhibition, referral, other.
☑ **Recording System**	When an inquiry arrives, exactly where is it recorded? Paper register, spreadsheet, CRM software, or not recorded at all?
☑ **Follow-Up**	What happens to an inquiry that does not immediately convert into an order? Is there a structured follow-up, or is it lost?
☑ **Tracking Status**	How does the team track whether each inquiry has been followed up, converted, or lost?
☑ **Lost Lead**	Has the business ever discovered that a customer tried to contact them and received no response? How did they find out? How often does this happen?
☑ **Conversion Gap**	Between an inquiry being received and an order being confirmed, what are the most common reasons a customer does not proceed?
☑ **Ideal**	What does the owner or manager describe as the ideal system for managing inquiries and follow-ups? Why has that system not been implemented?

4 DAY 1 STAKEHOLDER INTERACTIONS

Refer: Field Manual p. 8

☑ **Owner**	What does the owner consider the single biggest operational risk in the business right now? What data do they wish they had instantly available?
☑ **Owner: Pride**	Which process is the owner most proud of? Which process concerns them the most?
☑ **Manager**	What resource – time, data, equipment, or people – is the manager most often waiting for or running short of?
☑ **Manager: Gap**	What goes wrong most frequently on the floor that senior management may not fully be aware of?
☑ **Frontline**	Observe one frontline worker doing their actual work. What unofficial shortcut do they take because the standard process is too slow or broken?
☑ **Worker: Frustration**	What part of their daily work does the frontline worker describe as the most frustrating or the biggest waste of their time?
☑ **Unimplemented**	Across all Day 1 conversations: what improvement ideas do stakeholders already have that have not been implemented? What is preventing implementation?

DAY 2 Deep Investigation — Data, Resources & Waste

5 DATA CAPTURE, INFORMATION FLOW & COMMUNICATION

Refer: Field Manual pp. 9–10

☑ **Data Entry**	List every point in the business where data is captured. For each: is it paper, spreadsheet, dedicated software, or not captured at all?
☑ **Transfer Risk**	Identify every point where data moves from one system or person to another. Where are the highest risks of error during these transfers?
☑ **Duplication**	Where is the same information entered by more than one person in more than one place? How many times is a typical piece of data re-entered?

☑ **Data Usability**	Is the data being captured clean, consistent, and structured in a way that could support future automation or analytics? Or is it fragmented?
☑ **Communication**	How do instructions move from management to employees? How do employees report problems upward? Is there a defined channel?
☑ **Knowledge Retention**	When a mistake occurs, is it documented so others can learn from it? When an experienced employee leaves, what happens to the knowledge they carry?
☑ **Issue**	When something goes wrong, how is it reported and tracked? Is there a formal system or is it verbal? How is closure confirmed?
☑ **Reactive vs Proactive**	Does this organization identify problems before they escalate, or only after they become emergencies? Give a specific example.
☑ **Information**	Pick one piece of internal information — an issue report or internal request. Trace how long it takes to travel from Person A to Person C. Where does it get stuck?

6 FINANCIAL FLOWS & VENDOR COORDINATION

Refer: Field Manual pp. 10–11

☑ **Payment**	How does the business track payments due from customers? Is it a formal system, a spreadsheet, memory, or informal follow-up?
☑ **Vendor Payments**	How are outgoing payments to vendors managed? Are they tracked to avoid delays or missed obligations?
☑ **Cash Flow**	Are there situations where delayed customer payments create operational pressure – for example, inability to pay vendors or employees on time?
☑ **Last-Minute Crisis**	What is the most common cause of last-minute financial urgency in this business? How frequently does it occur?
☑ **Vendor**	Map the vendor ecosystem: who are the key suppliers, subcontractors, transporters, and service providers? How critical is each?
☑ **Delay Detection**	How does the business know when a vendor will be late? Do they find out in advance or only after the deadline is missed?
☑ **Vendor**	How is vendor performance and reliability assessed? Is selection based on historical data and evaluation, or personal relationships?
☑ **Vendor Perspective**	If you spoke with a vendor: what challenges do they face when working with this organization? What would they change?

7 MATERIAL, INVENTORY & RESOURCE UTILIZATION

Refer: Field Manual pp. 11–12

☑ **Storage**	Visit the storeroom or production floor. How are materials stored and labelled? Can any item be found without asking someone?
☑ **Dead Stock**	Is there evidence of materials sitting unused for a long time – dead stock, expired items, or materials for cancelled projects?
☑ **Shortage**	Are there materials that regularly run short and halt production or delay delivery? How often? What causes it?
☑ **Replenishment System**	Is there a formal system for tracking inventory levels and triggering reordering, or is purchasing reactive – only when stock runs out?
☑ **Critical**	What are the most expensive and most critical resources — machines, specialist staff, licensed software? Are they fully, under, or over utilized?
☑ **Utilization Evidence**	Are resource utilization decisions based on data, or on managerial judgment and experience? Can the business prove what it claims?
☑ **Imbalance**	Are any resources consistently idle during some periods and overloaded during others? What does that imbalance cost the business?

8 WASTE ANALYSIS & VALUE STREAM OBSERVATION

Refer: Field Manual pp.

12–13

⚠ *Mandatory: Observe one core process continuously for 30–60 minutes before answering these questions.*

☑ **Process**	Which specific process did you observe for 30-60 minutes? Describe the start point and end point of your observation.
☑ **Value-Added Time**	List all steps that directly transform or deliver value to the customer. Estimate the time spent on these steps.
☑ **Non-Value-Added**	List a minimum of 10 specific non-value-added activities you directly observed: waiting, searching, rework, duplication, unnecessary movement.
☑ **Waiting Waste**	Where specifically were people or materials sitting idle waiting for the next step? What caused the wait?
☑ **Rework**	Did you observe any work being repeated because it was not done correctly the first time? What caused the error?
☑ **Bottleneck Stage**	Which single step in the process you observed was the slowest or most frequently interrupted? What is the root cause of this bottleneck?
☑ **Worker**	When you shared your waste observations with the worker: did they agree? What additional waste did they identify that you missed?
☑ **VAT Ratio**	What is the approximate ratio of value-added time to total lead time for this process? What does this tell you about efficiency?

9 WORKPLACE, SAFETY, LAYOUT & ERGONOMICS

Refer: Field Manual pp. 13–14

☑ **Safety**	List every physical hazard you identified during your walkthrough: falling objects, electrical exposure, slippery surfaces, blocked exits, fire risks.
☑ **Past Incidents**	Have any accidents or near-misses occurred in the past year? How were they handled? What changed as a result?
☑ **5S**	Evaluate the workplace: does every item have a defined place? Are items stored where they are used? Is labelling clear and consistently maintained?
☑ **Floor Layout**	Draw a basic floor layout. Does the physical arrangement support the flow of work, or does it force unnecessary movement between connected activities?
☑ **Spatial**	Identify at least two specific cases where the layout creates unnecessary distance, movement, or confusion.
☑ **Energy Waste**	What examples of visible energy waste did you observe – idle machines, excessive lighting in empty spaces, poor insulation?
☑ **Ergonomics**	What postures or repetitive movements did you observe that are likely to cause fatigue or strain? Suggest at least three specific ergonomic improvements.

DAY 3 Validation, Management Visibility & Synthesis

10 MANAGEMENT VISIBILITY & DECISION-MAKING

Refer: Field Manual pp. 15–16

☑ **KPIs in**	What key performance indicators does management actually monitor? How and how frequently are they tracked?
☑ **Real-Time vs Delayed**	Is performance data available in real time, or does someone compile a report before management can see it? How long does that take?

☑ **Receivables Test**	How long does it take to answer: 'What is our current total outstanding receivable?' Can it be answered immediately or does it require time to compile?
☑ **Data vs Gut Feel**	Are decisions in this business based on structured data and defined metrics, or on the experience and intuition of the decision-maker? Give examples of both.
☑ **Missing Data**	What data does the owner wish they had immediately available that they currently cannot access quickly?
☑ **Collected But Unused**	What data is being collected but never used to make decisions? Where is it stored and why has it not been acted upon?
☑ **Planning System**	Does the organization have a formal daily, weekly, and monthly planning process? Describe what it looks like in practice.
☑ **10 Uncertainties**	List at least 10 specific uncertainties that arise regularly in this business because of insufficient or delayed planning.
☑ **Scalability Limit**	If demand doubled tomorrow, what specific system, person, or machine would break first? What would it take to remove that constraint?

11 CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE & EXTERNAL FEEDBACK

Refer: Field Manual pp. 16–17

☑ **Common Complaints**	What are the most common customer complaints or concerns? How frequently do they occur? What is the standard response?
☑ **Follow-Up Triggers**	At which points in the process are customers most likely to follow up with the business – chasing updates, confirmations, or corrections? What causes this?
☑ **Feedback Mechanism**	Is there a formal mechanism for collecting customer feedback? Does that feedback actually change how the business operates?
☑ **Customer Interview**	If you spoke with a customer: what frustrates them most about dealing with this business? What would make them more confident in doing business here?
☑ **Experience Gap**	What is the gap between how the business believes the customer experiences their service, and what the customer actually experiences?

12 IT SYSTEMS, DATA SAFETY & AUTOMATION OPPORTUNITY

Refer: Field Manual pp. 17–18

☑ **Software Inventory**	List every software tool and digital system used in this business: accounting, inventory, CRM, communication platforms, and any others.
☑ **Integration Status**	Are these systems integrated so that data flows automatically between them, or do they operate in silos requiring manual re-entry?
☑ **Data Storage**	Where is critical business data stored – local computers, shared server, cloud? What is the risk profile of each storage method?
☑ **Backup Protocol**	How frequently are backups taken? Where are they stored? Has the business tested whether data can actually be recovered from backup?
☑ **Data Loss History**	Has the business ever experienced a data loss event? What happened and what was the lasting impact?
☑ **Automation — Manual**	Which manual data entry or transfer points could be eliminated through system integration or automated capture?
☑ **Automation — Comms**	Which communication or follow-up tasks done by humans could be triggered automatically by a system event?
☑ **Dashboard Design**	What five or six numbers would give the owner real-time visibility into the health of their operations? Do any of these exist today?

13 VALIDATION, ROOT CAUSE & CLOSING SYNTHESIS

Refer: Field Manual pp. 18–19

☑ **Finding Validation**	For each of your top three findings: did the stakeholder confirm your observation? Was there context you had missed that changed your interpretation?
☑ **5 Whys — Problem 1**	Apply 5-Whys to your most important problem. What is the surface symptom? Trace it back through five levels to the true root cause.
☑ **5 Whys — Problem 2**	Apply 5-Whys to your second most important problem. Does the root cause surprise you compared to the surface symptom?
☑ **Hidden Workarounds**	List every unofficial step, undocumented shortcut, or informal workaround you uncovered across the visit. Why does each exist?
☑ **Owner's Priority**	In your closing interview with the owner: what do they believe is the single highest-impact improvement for their business?
☑ **Owner's Reaction**	When you presented your top findings to the owner: what was their reaction? Did any of your observations prompt them to think differently?
☑ **Edge Cases**	What happens when something goes wrong mid-process — a cancellation, a partial delivery, an incomplete record? Describe the exception process.
☑ **Three Changes**	If you were the owner: what are the three most important changes you would make, and exactly how would you implement each one?
☑ **Barrier Analysis**	For each of your three proposed changes: what specific constraint – budget, time, knowledge, resistance — is the biggest obstacle to implementation?
☑ **Comparative Insight**	Across all visits completed so far: what problems appear in every business regardless of industry? What does that pattern tell you?

VISIT COMPLETION DECLARATION

☑ I have asked every question in this checklist and documented my answers in a separate Answer Report.

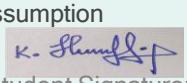
☑ I have applied the 4-Pillar Standard (Current State, Friction, Hidden Solution, Barrier) across all major areas.

☑ I have interviewed a minimum of 5 stakeholders: owner, manager, frontline employee, and at least one external stakeholder.

☑ I have conducted a 30-60 minute continuous waste observation and identified at least 10 non-value-added activities.

☑ I have drawn a floor layout and conducted safety and ergonomics walkthroughs.

☑ I have validated my findings with stakeholders and am confident my analysis is grounded in reality, not assumption



Student Signature: Date: 05.04.2026